

Not just Fun and Games

For a pastime most often associated with stereotypes of geeks, a shared gaming culture indicates the arrival of gaming as a mature and complex medium.

Currently, dozens of Internet-based multiplayer games exist in an assortment of different genres and styles, the most popular being real-time strategy and first-person shooters. According to recently published statistics, the online gaming industry will reach \$1.4 billion by the year 2002. Of these games, the popular ones are those which are more conducive to spectators and professional competition.

Computer games have also become more sophisticated in recent years with the advent of the Internet allowing players to hook up with other gamers around the world. To take things a step further, computer entertainment companies have elevated gaming to competition levels equalling that of professional sports.

Professional Game Providers (PGPs) like CPL and World Cyber Games organise big events, inviting top international players as well as the general public. The contests feature gaming action projected on large screens. And the players are not just playing for the thrill of it either. Gamers now come from far and wide to prove their mettle at live tournaments and LAN

parties. A multitude of gamers show up for worldwide tourneys, hoping to win bounties in excess of \$300,000!

Seoul kicked off the first World Cyber Games at Korea, with gamers around the world competing against each other. Cyberathletes from 37 countries, including India, took part in the proceedings. Net cafes and gaming dens have made no small contribution to gaming in South Korea. The country has a huge game-playing population and some 20-odd thousand gaming cafes. The life of a professional player in Korea has a lot of celebrity value attached to it; gamers are recognised on the streets by common people.

Gaming needs money, like any other sport. With the rapid growth of the gaming industry (it's currently valued at 20 billion dollars), it's possible to envision these competitions attaining a higher level of description than just a 'LAN party'. With high-profile event management of LAN parties such as Million Man LAN and the CPL, this phenomenon is as much a cultural indicator of the masses as Woodstock was in the 1960s. Gaming has evolved to the point where teams and clans represent countries, just like professional sports, and is poised to garner a whole lot of popularity and credibility for itself as a sport.



card, and plug the other end into the hub. Do this for all the computers on your network, and presto, you have a LAN! All that's left to do is fire up *Quake*, *Unreal Tournament* or any other TCP/IP based game (these days it's hard to find a multiplayer game that doesn't support TCP/IP). After this, all that is needed is some rad music and you have a party happening!

Looking around

If you're too lazy to go through the pain of organising a LAN party, you could look around for gaming centres or cyber cafe's around your neighbourhood. Dish-net DSL centers are serious about gaming and have well equipped machines. Of course, not every neighbourhood can have a place like Surf's up (Pune) or Hakone (Mumbai), with finely tweaked state-of-the-art computers, but your neighborhood cyber cafe would probably be a great place to hijack for a night.

Cyber cafes are not just places where people go to surf. All the computers are



ILLUSTRATIONS: Farzana Cooper

LAN Party. Before you throw a party, tell each of your guests to bring along:

- A computer with games already installed! (BYOC), or Bring Your Own Computer may sound daunting to some people, but you can't have a LAN without computers can you? Every person who wants to play has to get his gear along
- A spike buster to provide enough plugs for all your electrical devices
- A Network Card and some Network Cable (Network Cards are cheap, you can get one for as less as Rs 500)
- A barf bag, since five hours of continuous fragging can make anyone's stomach queasy

As the host, you should also have loads of caffeine-related beverage ready. Make sure all your guests have their network cards installed. It's best to have your guests do this before they arrive, as installing and troubleshooting everyone's hardware at the party is a real drag. Plug one end of a cable into your network



linked, fairly powerful and can be used to play multiplayer games. Most of the cyber cafe's that have turned into gaming dens have met with a good degree of success. Gaming is quite popular among the visitors, and as we all know and accept, addictive. The mix of playing games with other people is irresistible and should win every one over pretty soon. ■

SRIRAM SHARMA